

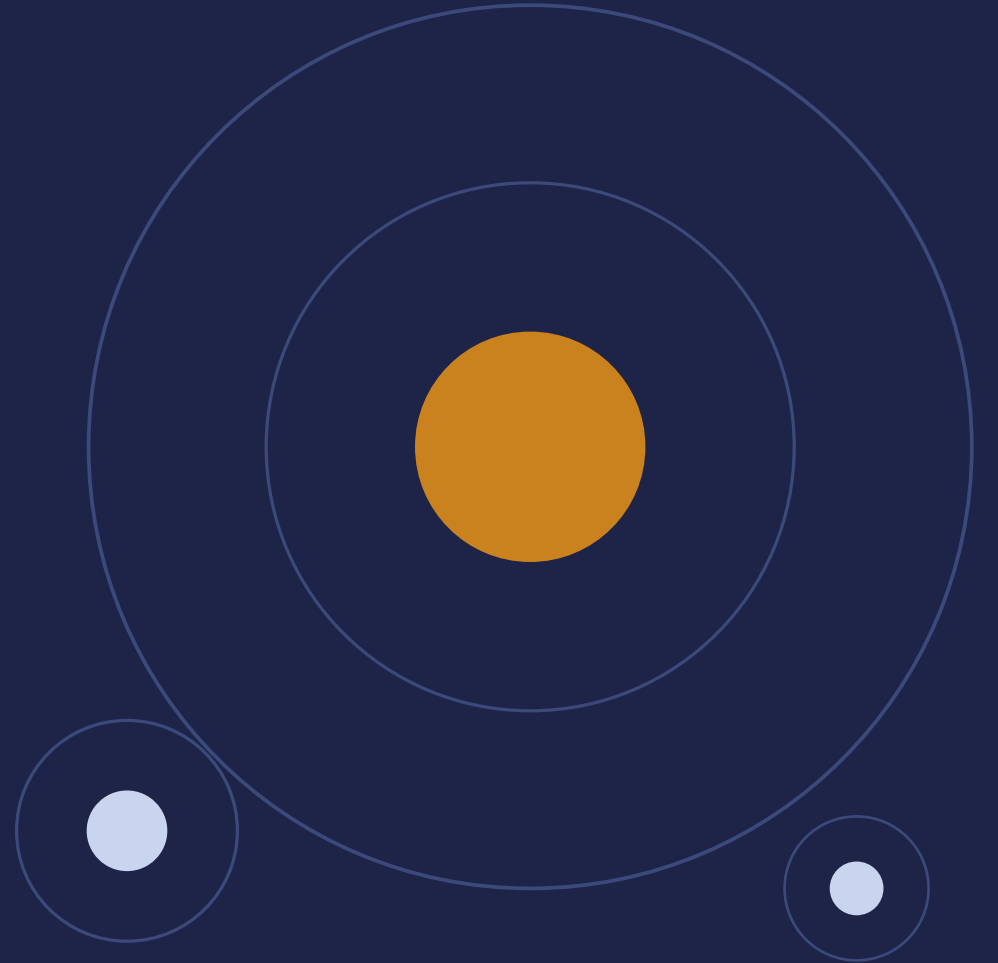
MADHYASTH DARSHAN · CO-EXISTENTIALISM

# Why Humans Are Not Just Material

*One question, three answers — Madhyasth Darshan, modern science, and Advaita Vedanta*

Based on Why Humans Are Not Just Material ([AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org](http://AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org))

Primary texts of Madhyasth Darshan, by Shri A. Nagraj — MVD · SB · JV (tr. Rakesh Gupta)





THE QUESTION

# Is a Human Just a Body?

Trained in physics and mathematics, it is hard to avoid the picture that consciousness is just something the brain does. Yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain unsettled. This study asks the question honestly and compares three serious answers.



## Science

A human is an organism: body + brain + culture. Mind is what the brain does — no second entity.



## Madhyasth Darshan

A human is body + jeevan — a real sentient self that works through the body. Matter promoted, not denied.



## Advaita Vedanta

You are not even an individual: the Self (Atman) is Brahman, and the world is dependent appearance (mithya).

Three answers to one question — each coherent from the inside, each unproven from the outside.



## ORIENTATION

# How We'll Compare the Three Views

Rather than take each view from start to finish, we line the three up on the same axis — first what lived experience shows, then what each says actually exists.

1

### **The question**

One human, three answers — science, Madhyasth Darshan, and Advaita.

2

### **Phenomenology**

The same lived, first-person experience — read by all three views.

3

### **Ontology**

What actually exists, and what a human is made of — in each view.

4

### **Method & comparison**

What each counts as evidence, and where the three agree and part.

5

### **Critical review**

Where each view is strong inside and vulnerable outside.



# Four Things a Purely Material Being Should Not Have

Read off lived experience — the one line of evidence anyone can check without instruments, scriptures, or laboratories.



## Two kinds of fulfilment

Fed, rested, healthy — yet unfulfilled; tired and hungry — yet content after acting justly. The two never substitute.



## Wanting past the body

We want happiness continuously; no amount of consumption delivers it. We grow, build, and create far beyond bodily need.



## A self the body doesn't exhaust

In sleep something still dreams; the sense of 'I' does not age like the knees. We say 'my body' as we say 'my house.'



## An unlearned moral demand

Children protest unfairness before anyone teaches them. Justice, truth, right conduct are recognised, not acquired.



SCIENCE · PHENOMENOLOGY

# Real — but Nothing beyond the Brain

Science does not dismiss first-person experience — it treats every felt distinction as real, but as what organised neural processing feels like from the inside. There is nothing beyond that activity: even the sense of being a self is an image the brain builds.

## Fulfilment

Bodily vs meaningful satisfaction both ride on the same nervous system — reward and valuation circuits, not a non-body satisfier.

## Unlimited wanting

Motivational systems built for pursuit, hedonic adaptation, and evolutionary mismatch — not a more-than-body want.

## The felt self

The 'I' is a model the brain constructs — narrative self-modeling, and altered brain states in sleep and dreaming — not a window onto a non-body self.

## Moral beginnings

Children's fairness is evolved cooperation and social learning — not an innate knowledge-order orientation.

**Public evidence, not private realisation: claims anyone can check, predictions that could fail — restricting what counts as proof.**



# Neti Neti — Not This, Not This

Turn attention inward and negate everything that presents itself as an object: the seer can never be the seen (drig-drishya-viveka). Whatever you can observe cannot be you, the observer — the same lived data, read as pointers to the witness.



## Everything felt is witnessed

Both fulfilments, all wanting, even the sense of 'me' — each appears to awareness, so each is 'not this.' In deep sleep even the mind subsides, yet something witnesses its absence.



## Scripture, reason, meditation

Hearing (shravana), reasoning (manana), and sustained meditation (nididhyasana) under a qualified teacher — confirmed within a contemplative lineage, not by public experiment.

**To Advaita, MD stopped too early — jeevan's desires are still observable. To MD, Advaita negated too far — dissolving the real, working self and the world with it.**



MADHYASTH DARSHAN · THE ANSWER

# Body + Jeevan, in One Real World



## The answer

A human is not only a body but body + jeevan — a real, sentient self that works through the body. So humans cannot be fully explained by matter-centric science alone.



## A fresh starting point

Science studied the human as a clever animal; mysticism declared the truth an unknowable mystery. Neither actually studied the human being — so a fresh start is needed.

*“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.”*

— MVD, The Alternative, point 7

**Matter is not denied or demoted — it is promoted: sentience is what matter becomes when fully developed.**



# Four Orders of Nature

Nature has four levels, each containing the ones below. Sentience is not spread across all matter — it enters at the animal order.

## Material

integrates

*insentient (jada)*

## Biological / prana

grows, vitalises

*insentient (jada)*

## Animal

hope to live enters — jeevan appears

*first sentient unit*

## Knowledge

knows, evaluates, uses all nature

*jeevan through a human body*

*each higher order contains the lower ones → humans belong to the knowledge order*

**Knowledge order — essential nature: fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, compassion; purpose (dharma): happiness.**





# Sentience Is Developed Atom

The sentient unit is not a second substance added from outside. Development is built into existence.



## The sentient atom is the jeevan

An atom that becomes constitutionally complete (gathanpurnata) crosses irreversibly into sentient status — and that sentient atom is the jeevan.



## Latency actualised, not emergence

Sentience is ever-present intelligibility reaching active form at a stable configuration — not strong emergence from wholly non-experiential matter.

**Post-death continuity is a *separate* commitment: configurations begin and end; jeevan persistence is inferred from constitutional immortality with conservation.**



# Body and Self Are Not the Same



## Different jobs

Eating and sleeping serve the body; values and evaluation serve jeevan. When the body sleeps, jeevan does not. Different jobs — not the same thing.



## Joint form

A human is the body and jeevan together — not reducible to either alone. The brain (medhas) is the medium jeevan works through, not the producer of sentience.



## The wisdom layer

Awakened humans express five functional layers (koshas); the fifth — vigyanmaya — enables knowledge, wisdom, science. Animals have four; matter has two.

*“The body is not jeevan, and jeevan is not the body. Jeevan is eternal, and the body is merely a vehicle and medium for jeevan.”*

— SB, Ch. 7



SCIENCE · ONTOLOGY

# Mind Is What the Brain Does



## The answer

A human is an evolved organism — a body with an extraordinarily complex nervous system shaped by evolution and culture. Mind is not a second entity.



## Method

Methodological naturalism: public measurement and replication. Explaining experience starts from organised matter, not a second substance.

**Five replies parallel Madhyasth Darshan's five ontological steps:**

- **Continuity, not four orders** gradients of complexity; no threshold where 'hope to live' enters
- **Mind emerges from organisation** destroy the organisation (brain death) and the phenomena cease
- **No second entity** no instrument detects a sentient unit separate from brain activity
- **Culture + brain, not a knower** symbol use and cumulative culture, not a knowledge-order self
- **Layered function, not koshas** distributed cortical & subcortical systems



SCIENCE · ONTOLOGY

# The Interaction Problem

If a separate self drives the body, there must be a junction where intention becomes muscle motion. Physiology finds none — every movement traces back through neurons obeying ordinary physics. This is the causal-closure objection, sharpened by physics.



## The dilemma

An interacting jeevan must either inject energy into a closed physical system (violating conservation) — or rearrange energy with no detectable surplus or deficit. No reproducible anomaly has been found.



## MD's non-Cartesian reply

The human is a joint form in which jeevan coordinates through state and order transmission within effort–motion–result — not joule injection. Whether that satisfies causal closure remains open.

**The bar is high: an interacting jeevan must be either causally inert — and then it does not 'drive' the body — or measurably depart from closed physical prediction.**



SCIENCE · WHAT IT LEAVES OPEN

# What Science Leaves Open



## The hard problem

Science explains the functions of mind increasingly well — but why physical processing is accompanied by felt experience at all remains unsolved.



## Sentience in matter?

Respected philosophers take panpsychism seriously — consciousness as fundamental to matter. Not established science, and none claims the conscious unit survives death.

**Hard Problem ≠ rahasyata: MD treats mystery as removable deficit in the knower's reflection — a different commitment from leaving consciousness explanatorily open.**

*Science does not demote matter or promote a second substance — it explains function from organisation while leaving the deepest why-of-experience unsettled: the mirror image of MD's claim that sentience is matter fully developed.*



# You Are Not Even an Individual

Advaita begins from witness-consciousness: not a clever animal, not body plus sentient atom, but the irreducible seer presupposed in every experience.



## **Brahman alone is real**

The world is appearance (mithya) — dependent, not ultimately real. Brahma satyam, jagat mithya.



## **Not the body — or the mind**

Whatever you can observe cannot be the observer. Even the working mind and felt inner agent are not-self.



## **The self is not individual**

The separate person (jiva) is appearance caused by ignorance. Liberation is recognising the Self was always Brahman.

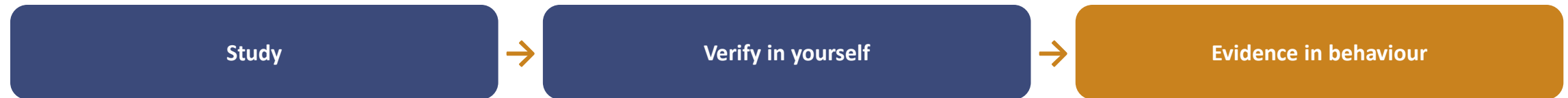
**'Is the human just material?' assumes a separate human in an independent world. Advaita: there is only Brahman — so the question dissolves.**



MADHYASTH DARSHAN · THE PROPOSED TEST

# Not Belief — Self-Verification and Evidence

Madhyasth Darshan does not ask for belief on authority. Understanding is complete only when it becomes clear in one's own seeing, stable in conviction, and evident in conduct.



**The evidence chain: Realisation — Behaviour — Experiment.** Realisation is ultimate evidence only when it becomes manifest in resolution, work, and conduct — and closes as authentic proof (pramanikta) when it can be conveyed to another.

**Open question: can conduct-based criteria distinguish awakened practitioners from controls in a pre-registered, inter-subjective test?**



COMPARING THE THREE VIEWS

# One Question, Three Answers

|                    | Science                     | Madhyasth Darshan             | Advaita Vedanta                       |
|--------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| What is a human?   | Body + brain + culture      | Body + jeevan (sentient unit) | Atman = Brahman; person is appearance |
| Is the world real? | Yes — and all there is      | Yes — real and perpetual      | Only provisionally; finally mithya    |
| Consciousness?     | Emergent brain process      | Nature of a developed atom    | The only reality there is             |
| How many selves?   | One per brain; none survive | Many, forever distinct        | Ultimately one, without a second      |
| Survives death?    | Nothing                     | Jeevan, intact                | Question misposed — never born        |
| Method             | Measurement, experiment     | Study + conduct-evidence      | Scripture, reason, meditation         |





COMPARING THE THREE VIEWS

# Contrasts — and Where the Alliances Fall



## On the body

Science: the body is the whole human. Advaita: the body is finally unreal. MD takes the middle — real, but the jeevan's vehicle (madhyasth).



## On the self

Science: no self beyond the brain. Advaita: one universal Self. MD: many selves, permanently individual — so relationships are fully real.



## On matter & mind

Science: mind from matter. Advaita: matter from mind. MD: mind is matter at its highest development.

**Where the alliances fall.** Against the materialist, MD and Advaita agree: the human is not just the body. Against Advaita, MD and science agree: the world is real. Against both, science insists nothing survives death.



# Each Strong Inside, Vulnerable Outside

## Madhyasth Darshan

+ Strength: integrates ontology, self, and ethics; proposes a test; avoids the combination problem.

— Weakness: conclusion built into the premise; 'different jobs' doesn't prove two things; constitutional completeness and interaction unexplained; risks unfalsifiability.

## Scientific materialism

+ Strength: unmatched explanatory and predictive success; the only method that systematically catches its own errors.

— Weakness: the hard problem stands; explains the known, not the knower; method quietly promoted to metaphysics; little to say about meaning.

## Advaita Vedanta

+ Strength: starts from the one undeniable datum — consciousness; rigorous 1,200-year tradition; the observer-argument is serious.

— Weakness: world-as-appearance is uncheckable; must explain the ignorance it denies; ethics is preparatory, not ultimate; warrant is scriptural.



THE BOTTOM LINE

# The Real Disagreement Is About Evidence

All three views are partly armoured against refutation — science by ruling first-person evidence out of bounds, Madhyasth Darshan by attributing dissent to lack of awakening, Advaita by demoting the empirical world. The genuine disagreement is about what counts as evidence: instruments, conduct, or contemplative insight. No experiment settles that choice.

**What would actually move the debate:**

- **A measurable neural anomaly** deviation from physical prediction — would support a real, interacting jeevan
- **A complete mechanistic account** of valuation and felt experience — would remove the work jeevan and Atman do
- **A pre-registered conduct test** reliably distinguishing practitioners from controls

**Until then: parallel accounts — each coherent from inside, each unproven from outside.**

WHY HUMANS ARE NOT JUST MATERIAL

# Three Answers, One Honest Question

- **Science** the human is a body; mind is what the brain does — powerful method, unfinished story.
- **Madhyasth Darshan** body + jeevan; matter promoted to sentience — real self, real world, an open interaction problem.
- **Advaita Vedanta** only Brahman is real; the person is appearance — most radical, at a steep price.

*The question of what a human is turns on what we will accept as evidence — and that choice is ours to examine, not science's alone to settle.*

